

Language and the World

(Words and Things)

3 parts to the lecture

- 1) The relation between language and thought (and culture) –
 - Linguistic Relativity
 - Linguistic Determinism
- 2) Language and Gender
 - Spender
 - De Beauvoir
- 3) Language and the legacy of colonialism
 - Ngũgĩ
 - Achebe

The Sapir-Whorf hypothesis

- **Linguistic relativity**
- This is the 'belief that each language embodies and perpetuates a particular world view' (Brown, 1968: 230).
- This suggests that the members of a society or a country who speak a common language share both a language and a specific way of viewing and understanding "reality".
- 'The speakers of a language are partners to an agreement to perceive and think of the world in a certain way' (Brown, 1968: 230).

How Many Words for Snow?



- It is sometimes said that “Eskimos” have over 50 words for “snow”.
- I have put the word “Eskimos” in inverted commas for a reason –
- The term “Eskimo” is neither accurate nor appropriate in acting as a name for a group of people
- It is a first indication of the the power inherent in language to try to “capture” groups of people
- **Problems with inequality in language are also problems within the world** (I will come back to this).
- Samson, C., (2003). [A Way of Life That Does Not Exist: Canada and the Extinguishment of the Innu.](#) Verso.

A different world?...



- The question assumes that “Eskimos” live in an environment where snow and ice play an important part so a wide range of words for snow is required to be able to live.
- This means that “Eskimos” see the world differently and this is reflected in their language;
- There is a link between language, thinking and understanding the world.
- The greater number of words for snow points to the fact that they live in a very different world from “us”.
- This is an example of the “Sapir-Whorf hypothesis” This term comes from the merging of the names of two “pioneers” of linguistics, Benjamin Lee Whorf (1897-1941) and his mentor, Edward Sapir (1884-1939).



A second aspect of Sapir-Whorf hypothesis

Linguistic determinism

This is an even stronger claim. It asserts that in addition to the link between a given language and a particular way of seeing the world.

How we think of the world is *determined* by the language that we use. So: 'The languages of the world are so many moulds of varying shape into which infant minds are poured' (Brown, 1968: 231).

This is a powerful argument. But it has some problems.

- Any use of human language expresses human thoughts about the world.
- Each language constitutes a specific rendering of a specific “reality”, rather than an accurate or objective picture of the world.
- “We” (humans with language) seem to have lost any innocent contact with the world, as our language always “gets in the way”.



More Problems

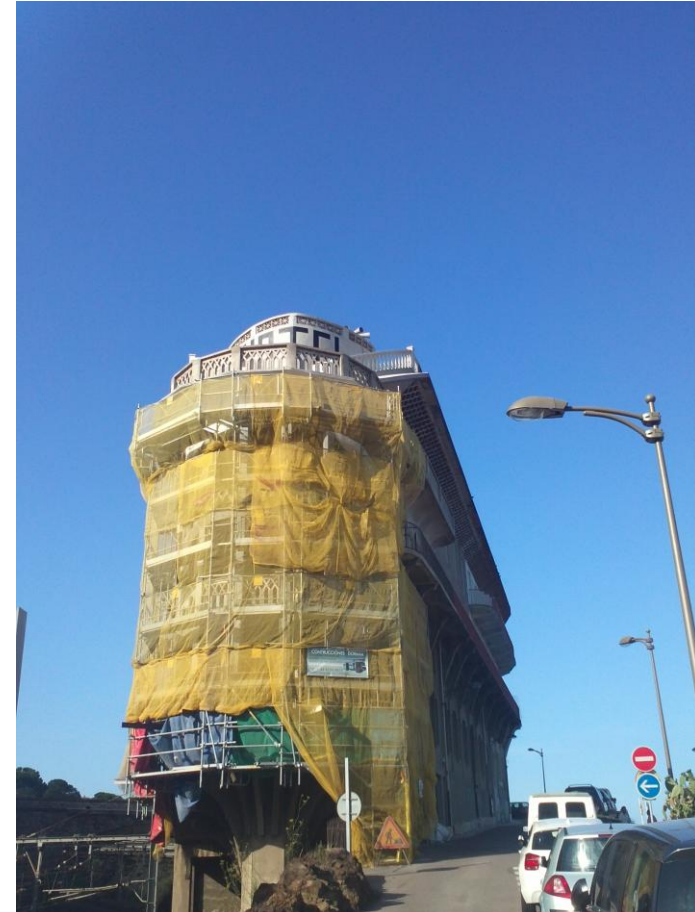
- When outlining the “Eskimo” example, I used the following phrase: “they live in a very different world from ‘us’”.
- This raises the question of who is included in this “us”?
- It assume there is an “us” and a “them”
- Who is the “them”?
- The “others”
- There is the danger of assigning completely different “realities” or worldviews to speakers of so-called indigenous groups (in the Amazon rainforest, for example.)
- In turn, this implies that this Western outlook sets the benchmark against which other worldviews are judged (see lecture on Modernity as a Colonial Project)
- It also involves playing down the differences between individual European languages, and assuming there is such a thing as a “Western outlook”

Another (interesting) point (if we have time)....

- The Sapir-Whorf hypothesis assumes that single words are the main way of indicating the things of the world.
- If there are three different words for snow in “Eskimo” which do not directly map on to three different words in English, then those who speak “Eskimo” must think of snow and the world differently.
- This forgets that English speakers, especially those who make snowballs, are often aware of different kinds of snow but use phrases rather than individual words to describe these; examples of such phrases might be: “good snow for packing”, “bad snow for packing”.
- English-speakers may not have as many individual words for snow as “Eskimos” are imagined to have, but have as many possible phrases for snow as they do.

Dale Spender on “Man-Made Language”

- ‘Undoubtedly our own meanings are partially hidden from us and it is difficult to have access to them. We may use the English language our whole lives without ever noticing the distortions and omissions’ Spender, 1980: 145
- ‘although it is not always easy to get outside this language trap, to get outside the limitations of one's own language, it is not impossible. There are clues, if one is prepared to look for them.’ Spender, 1980: 145



Something to read (later)

- Sexism and dictionaries...

<https://www.theguardian.com/lifeandstyle/2019/jul/03/hussy-baggage-bit-filly-dictionary-definitions-woman>

Dale Spender – Man Made Language

- One key ideas which we can see in the operation in the language is that of the **male-as-norm**.
- This supports the idea there is one standard or normal human being is a male one
- Those who are not part of this standard are in some way “deviant”
- ‘Our fundamental classification scheme is one which divides humanity not into two equal parts (if two is to be the significant number) but into those who are plus male and those who are minus male.’
- The status of the female is derived from the status of the male and on this has been erected many strata of positive and negative classifications.



“Men Before Women” - Where do such ideas come from?

- Spender finds some historical evidence for men being given priority in language (and the world)
- ‘The first record we appear to have is that of a Mr Wilson in 1553 who insisted that it was more natural to place the man before the woman, as for example in male and female, husband and wife, brother and sister, son and daughter. Implicit in his insistence that males take precedence is the belief that males 'come first' in the natural order, and this is one of the first examples of a male arguing for not just the superiority of males but that this superiority should be reflected in the structure of the language.’ Spender, 1980: 147



More Evidence

- 'In 1746 John Kirkby formulated his' Eighty Eight Grammatical Rules' These rules ' the product of Mr Kirkby 's own imagination, contained one that indicated the esteem in which he held females: Rule Number Twenty One stated that the male gender was more comprehensive than the female. This represents a significant departure from the simple proposition that males are more important.' Spender, 1980: 148

Men take themselves and language for granted.

- Men do not have to explain that they are writing “as a man”. It is seen as normal, as “natural” even.
- “A man would never set out to write a book on the peculiar situation of the human male. But if I wish to define myself, I must first of all say: ‘I am a woman’ [...] (De Beauvoir, 1988: 15)
- Women do not share this privilege; they are immediately seen as “women writers”. Their thoughts and writings do not come out of nowhere (as appears to be the case for men), they are not pure and objective (as male writers might claim for themselves).



Actors and Actresses

- David Marsh, who was the production editor of *The Guardian* newspaper, David Marsh, insists that journalists on this newspaper never use the word “actress” but only that of “actor”.
- One reason for this is that the word “actress” is seen as limiting. In a theatre company, to describe a person as the best “actress” is to compare them to the other female actors in the group.
- To call someone the best “actor” is not simply to state that they are the best male actor, but that they are the best at acting in the company.
- The masculine term (actor) can include the female, but not the other way around.
- The female has been subsumed into the male (again).
- “Actor” also stands in for the neuter (where the gender of the person acting is not known), so the balance is skewed. Given that those individuals working in the theatre and cinema are performing comparable roles, the argument is that they should all be called “actors” (and paid equally for equal work).



Marsh's argument seems good, but...

- ...The specific history of our society and our language is one in which most occupations, such as that of doctor, teacher, actor were carried out by men.
- Women, and the female version, were rare, even peculiar. They needed further explanation.
- Apparently neutral words, such as actor, provide a yardstick which may not immediately appear to refer to the male, or to be masculine...
- but is there a risk that by calling all women “actors” we are lumping them in to what is really a “masculine” term?
- We may pay lip-service to the problem of language and gender but might also ignore the more fundamental problem.
- This is part of the problem/issue of “political correctness” and there is no easy answer! But it is important to think about it.



What is to be done? (To READ LATER????)

- 'For women to become visible, it is necessary that they become linguistically visible...New symbols will need to be created and old symbols will need to be recycled and invested with new images if the male hold of language is to be broken. As the language structure which has been devised and legitimated by male grammarians exacts ambiguity, uncertainty, and anomie for females, then in the interests of dismantling the muted nature of females, that language structure and those rules need to be defied.' Spender, 1980: 162



English as a “Colonial” language

- Ngũgĩ
- Kenyan novelist, writer and thinker
- 1938-
- <https://ngugiwathiongo.com/>
- Novels, such as:
- *A Grain of Wheat*
- *Weep Not, Child*

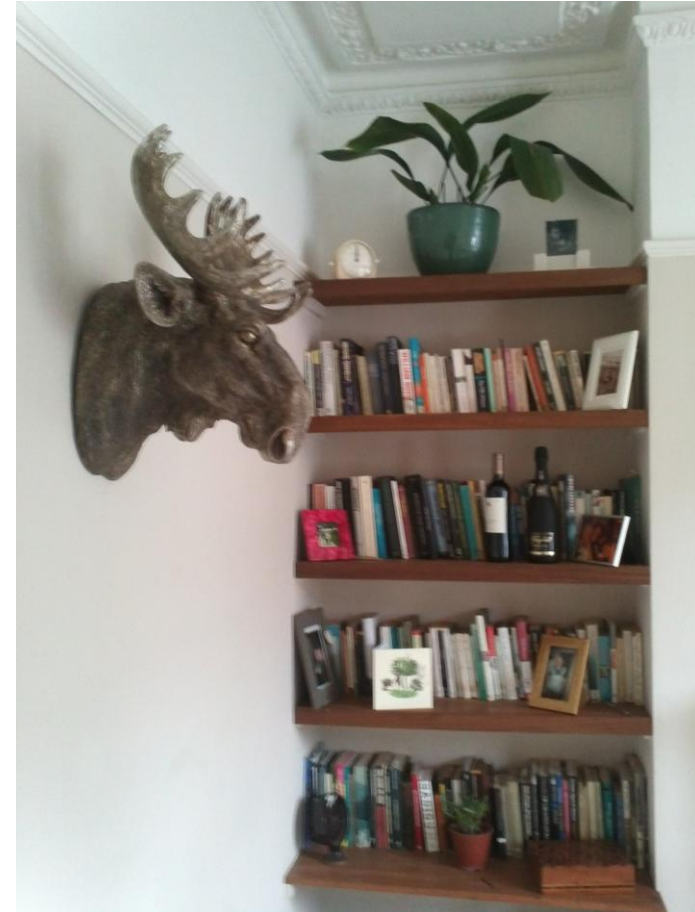
Ngũgĩ – Imperialism of Language (from the reading for this week)

- Language as weapon of colonization
- Suppresses original (“indigenous”) culture and language
- Education is carried out in the language of the colonizer
- ‘The English language was the bearer of all knowledge in the arts and sciences’
Ngũgĩ, 2008: 33
- No languages of African origin among the official languages of the UN.
- Ngũgĩ is not against a common language for “nation to speak unto nation”...
- He just thinks it should not be one with a history of inequality and colonialism.



Achebe

- Chinua Achebe 1930-2013
- Nigerian novelist and writer
- *Things Fall Apart* (1958)
- Achebe aims to “Africanize English”
- A world writer....(The title his 1958 novel quotes W.B. Yeats, an Irish poet)



- For Achebe, writing in one of the official Nigerian languages like Hausa, Igbo and Yoruba, means that the writer is only communicating with a smaller group of people
- Writing in these languages would restrict the number of readers, pointing out that many Africans are acquiring English or French as their first language
- He maintains that writing in English is not a sign of submission or of abandoning his first language (Igbo) –
- it is not right for anyone to abandon their first language but he has no choice.
- Therefore African writers should continue to write in English or French or Portuguese.

Achebe, 1997: *Transitions*

- ‘The African writer should aim to use English in a way that brings out his message best without altering the language so much that its value as a medium of international exchange will be lost. He should aim at fashioning an English that is at once universal and able to carry his peculiar experience. I have in mind here the writer who has something new, something different, to say.’ Achebe, 1997: 347

- ‘So my answer to the question, "Can an African ever learn English well enough to be able to use it effectively in creative writing?" is certainly, "Yes." If on the other hand you ask, "Can he ever learn to use it like a native speaker?" I should say, "I hope not." It is neither necessary nor desirable for him to be able to do so. The price a world language must be prepared to pay is submission to many different kinds of use’
Achebe, 1997: 347

And what of other languages?

- Welsh
- Gaelic
- Cornish

Extra Stuff....

Rethinking “Sex” and Gender (Simone de Beauvoir)

- Many sociologists ascribe the distinction between “sex” and gender to Simone de Beauvoir in her 1949 text *The Second Sex*
- *But*, this division is not as clear-cut in de Beauvoir’s work as is sometimes thought to be the case.
- This is not to suggest that making a distinction between “sex” and gender is “wrong”, but it does need to be approached with care.
- In *The Second Sex*, de Beauvoir states that her main aim is to ask (and respond to) the question: ‘what is a woman?’ (de Beauvoir, 1988 [1953]: 13).
- In the Introduction to the second volume, she writes: ‘When I use the words *woman* or *feminine* I obviously refer to no archetype, no changeless essence’ (de Beauvoir, 1988: 31. Emphasis in original).
- De Beauvoir argues that the question of the experience of the existence, of “woman” has not previously been addressed.
- There is a lack of thought about the status of “woman” and the lives of women.
- However, de Beauvoir does not make a strict division between these two elements - de Beauvoir does not reduce the question of what a woman “is” to the biological (“sex”);
- Likewise, the lived societal experience of women (“gender”) is not purely “social”.

Gender in language (according to grammarians)

- In his influential book *A Dictionary of Modern English Usage*, H.W. Fowler states that gender ‘is a grammatical term only. To talk of *persons or creatures of the masculine or feminine g[ender]*, meaning *of the male or female sex* is either a jocularity (permissible or not according to context) or a blunder’.(Fowler, 1937 [1926]: 211).
- Fowler is drawing on the original Latin meaning of the word “*genus*” from which the modern word “gender” is derived.
- *Genus* indicates a “type” or “kind”, and is related to the word “genre”.
- In this sense, grammatical gender, simply indicates a genre, a kind or category into which words are placed.
- The world is organized according to arbitrary (human) categories, in this case, that of “gender”, into which different words such as nouns and pronouns are sifted and sorted.
- To ask if such genders, or genres or categories, are, of themselves, biologically “sexed” is, for Fowler, a mistake, even a joke.